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Measuring moral disengagement with a situational judgment test: Advancing the assessment of an important workplace construct

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Abstract

Moral disengagement (MD) has been characterized as a uniquely important predictor of counterproductive work behaviors (CWBs). This study describes the development and validation of a situational judgment test (SJT) for measuring MD in the workplace, which offers potential advantages over existing Likert-type scales. The development/validation efforts involved two independent rounds of subject-matter expert (SME) review and data collected from three independent samples. The resulting test, labeled the MD-SJT, displayed high reliability, was related to an established measure of MD as well as hypothesized personality variables, and was incrementally predictive of CWBs above the established measure of MD. This study advances knowledge pertaining to the assessment of MD, which is a critically important construct in the workplace.

KEYWORDS

counterproductive work behaviors, moral disengagement, situational judgment tests, testing/assessment

1 | INTRODUCTION

Unethical or inappropriate behaviors at work—often described as counterproductive work behaviors (CWBs)—have numerous negative consequences. Such consequences can range from job loss and tarnished careers at the individual-level, to lost profit and corporate scandals at the organization-level (e.g., Volkswagen emissions scandal; Cavico & Mujtaba, 2016), as well as lost lives and environmental damage at the societal-level (e.g., Deepwater Horizon oil spill; Pallardy, 2019; White et al., 2012). Accordingly, it is of great value to consider predictors of such behaviors so that preventative efforts, including employee selection and training, can be enacted to minimize their occurrence. Toward this end, the construct of moral disengagement (MD) holds much promise as an explanatory mechanism for the occurrence of CWBs (Moore et al., 2012). Broadly speaking, MD reflects various rationalization mechanisms that individuals can use to circumvent feelings of guilt or self-censure that typically accompany inappropriate conduct, in turn facilitating the occurrence of such conduct (Treviño et al., 2014). Building on prior work in this area, Moore et al. (2012) commented that the propensity for MD is 'a uniquely important predictor of a broad range of unethical behaviors' (p. 3), in turn supporting the value of assessing this construct in organizational settings. The aim of the present study was to develop and validate a situational judgment test (SJT) for measuring MD in relation to work, which we refer to as the MD-SJT.[1]

Several considerations highlight the value and contribution of this study. First, the MD-SJT fills the need for an explicitly work-focused and contextualized measure of MD. Various available scales exist for measuring MD, but such scales have been developed in relation to nonwork applications (e.g., Bandura et al., 1996; Boardley & Kavussanu, 2007), or represent adapted versions of prior scales developed on an ad hoc

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basis (Detert et al., 2008). As a means on reconciling the existence of various available measures, Moore et al. (2012) developed a general measure of the propensity for MD (hereafter, the Moore MD measure). Although the Moore MD measure was thoroughly validated and has favorable psychometric properties, it was explicitly designed so that it could be 'used generally—that is, with any adult sample in any type of context…' (p. 3). Although this feature allows for flexibility in use, the intentionally general focus comes at the expense of fidelity to the workplace context. Thus, there is a need for measures that focus on MD in relation to work.

Second, building on the preceding point, there are both practical and legal reasons to favor a work-focused, as opposed to general-focused, measure of MD. A growing body of research in the domain of personality measurement highlights the potential value of measures that are directly work-contextualized (Hunthausen et al., 2003; Lievens et al., 2008; Shaffer & Postlethwaite, 2012). This is based on the idea that contextualization has the potential to reduce measurement error and improve predictive validity, as respondents are less likely to provide responses based on various idiosyncratic domains of life (e.g., school and romantic), and instead will provide responses directly relevant to the intended domain of application (e.g., work; Fisher et al., 2017). This same logic can be extended to the measurement of MD. Furthermore, contextual alignment with the workplace has the added potential benefits of explicit job relevance and improved legal defensibility (Equal Employment Opportunity Commission, Civil Service Commission, Department of Labor, & Department of Justice, 1978).

Third, the SJT format may be particularly valuable for realizing the benefits of a work-focused MD measure. MD is inherently situational in nature. That is to say, the occurrence or expression of MD—even if based on a general underlying propensity—manifests as rationalizations about specific behaviors that can be enacted in a particular situational context. In this regard, the SJT format allows for the presentation of detailed situational scenarios, unlike the characteristically short items typically found in Likert-type scales. Similarly, the use of situational scenarios allows for increased workplace fidelity as scenarios can be written to directly focus on the work context, in contrast with the intentionally general focus of the Moore MD measure. Lievens and Motowidlo (2016) describe SJTs 'as contextualized selection procedures that capture candidate responses to [or judgments about] a set of relevant job situations' (p. 3). Thus, the SJT format allows for the presentation of relevant situations, such as those implicating CWBs, that provide contextualized opportunities for the expression (and corresponding measurement) of MD.

Fourth, despite a focus on the work context, the use of multiple SJT scenarios affords the potential for flexibility in use. In the case of the MD-SJT, as described below, the scenarios implicate varied categories of CWBs as a means of assessing MD (e.g., misuse of information, interpersonal misconduct, and unsafe behavior), suggesting the possibility of a selective focus on particular scenarios of interest, further increasing relevance and precision. Fifth, although existing SJTs have attempted to capture integrity-related constructs (e.g., Becker, 2005; de Meijer et al., 2010), to the best of our knowledge this is the only SJT to explicitly target the construct of MD, thus making a novel contribution to the literature. Finally, from a procedural perspective, we describe our approach for developing this SJT, which was created with specific design features to be construct-focused and internally consistent, such that others might benefit from this example.

In what follows, we first elaborate on the MD construct domain, which represents the domain to be measured by the MD-SJT. Second, we review the CWB criterion domain, which represents the domain that is the focus of prediction. Third, we provide an overview of SJTs, along with further details regarding the current study.

2 | CONSTRUCT DOMAIN TO BE MEASURED: PROPENSITY FOR MD

Moral disengagement has been defined as 'a set of cognitive mechanisms that deactivate moral self-regulatory processes and thereby help to explain why individuals often make unethical decisions without apparent guilt or self-censure' (Detert et al., 2008, p. 374). The construct of MD is based on Albert Bandura's social cognitive theory, which suggests that ethical behavior is guided by internalized standards of appropriate conduct and morality (Bandura, 1999; Treviño et al., 2014). However, people often encounter situations where unethical, immoral, or otherwise inappropriate behavior might be personally beneficial. In such circumstances, one's internal standards of morality can be selectively disengaged (i.e., MD) so that one can act unethically without feeling guilty. This is accomplished via eight interrelated mechanisms of rationalization that collectively constitute the MD construct space, which are summarized in Table 1. Prior work has theoretically conceptualized and empirically substantiated that these various MD mechanisms are internally consistent and reflect a unidimensional construct (Moore et al., 2012). The notion that people use rationalizations as a means of engaging in self-serving behavior has been described in other theories of moral conduct (e.g., Barkan et al., 2015), suggesting the deeply rooted nature of this phenomenon. Furthermore, it has been argued that people systematically differ in their propensity for MD (e.g., Detert et al., 2008; Moore et al., 2012; Treviño et al., 2014), which clearly positions this construct as an individual difference variable that can be used for predicting relevant workplace outcomes such as CWBs.

3 | CRITERION DOMAIN OF INTEREST: CWBS

CWBs have been defined as 'any volitional acts by employees that potentially violate the legitimate interests of, or do harm to, an organization or its stakeholders' (Marcus et al., 2016, p. 204; also see Sackett & DeVore, 2001). Inherent in this definition is that the implicated behaviors are volitional acts, but they need not have malicious intent (Sackett & DeVore, 2001). In other words, behaviors can be unethical or in contrast to organizational interests even if employees do not intend to cause harm (e.g., skipping work under

TABLE 1 Summary of moral disengagement (MD) mechanisms

Category	Description
Moral Justification	Refers to justifying inappropriate behavior by viewing the behavior as promoting a valued or desirable outcome. For example, justifying theft from the rich in order to help those who are less fortunate
Euphemistic labeling	Refers to covering-up the inappropriate nature of an action by labeling the action with neutral or 'cute' language. For example, referring to theft as 'borrowing something' or describing the act of lying as 'glossing over the truth'
Advantageous comparison	Refers to comparing inappropriate behavior with other behavior that is even worse, attempting to make the original behavior seem harmless by comparison. For example, justifying verbal abuse since it's not physical assault
Displacement of responsibility	Refers to placing the responsibility for one's own actions on other people or external circumstances. For example, justifying fraudulent activity because one was following orders from a superior
Diffusion of responsibility	Refers to avoiding responsibility for an action when that action is also conducted by several others in a group, crowd, or team. For example, justifying something using the argument that everyone else does it too
Distortion of consequences	Refers to minimizing or down-playing the importance of negative consequences associated with inappropriate behavior. For example, viewing illegal graffiti painting as a victimless crime, no big deal, or nothing to worry about
Dehumanization	Refers to viewing the victims of inappropriate behavior as less-than-human, in turn removing the need for basic human consideration. For example, justifying poor treatment of someone because you say they behave like an animal
Attribution of blame	Refers to placing the responsibility for inappropriate actions on the victims of such actions. For example, using the argument that the victim is deserving of the treatment they receive

TABLE 2 Summary of counterproductive work behavior (CWB) categories

Category	Description
Theft or related behavior	Refers to taking or giving away money, supplies, property, or other materials without permission, as well as helping others to do so
Alcohol or drug use	Refers to the possession or use of drugs or alcohol while at work, in addition to using these in a manner that is against company policy
Destruction of property	Refers to defacing, destroying, or otherwise damaging company supplies, property, materials, work areas, or means of production
Misuse of information	Refers to inappropriate use or treatment of information, such as falsifying records, sharing confidential information, or withholding information
Misuse of time or resources	Refers to inappropriate use of work resources, such as wasting time, taking extra-long breaks, or doing personal errands with work equipment
Interpersonal misconduct	Refers to inappropriate behavior when interacting with others at work, such as verbal abuse, physical gestures, yelling, inappropriate jokes/pranks, or sexual behavior
Poor quality work	Refers to intentionally doing slow or sloppy work, for example, working slowly/poorly out of retaliation, boredom, or to achieve a personal objective
Unsafe behavior	Refers to behavior that puts yourself or others in danger, such as not following safety procedures, not wearing safety gear, or operating equipment unsafely
Poor attendance	Refers to unexcused absences or lateness for work, such as habitually showing up late, intentionally missing work, or using sick leave when not sick

false pretenses to see friends). In light of this definition, there are various behaviors that fall within this broad domain. Although different frameworks and taxonomies have been created to organize CWBs (e.g., Bennett & Robinson, 2000; Spector et al., 2006), the most comprehensive summary of this construct space appears to be the model advanced by Gruys and Sackett (2003). Table 2 provides a summary of common CWB categories based on this model, with two slight modifications—drug and alcohol use were combined into a single category, and likewise, inappropriate verbal and physical actions were combined under the label of interpersonal misconduct. As alluded to in the introduction above, the cumulative cost of CWBs is staggering—estimated to be trillions of dollars annually (Moore et al., 2012)—suggesting this to be a critically important criterion for prediction.

There are various reasons to suspect that MD would be predictive of CWBs. First, MD can be seen as indicative of low integrity.

Broadly speaking, the notion of integrity refers to personal adherence to ethical and moral standards. In contrast to this, MD represents the process through which ethical and moral standards are selectively deactivated, allowing individuals to engage in inappropriate conduct without feelings of guilt or self-censure. Accordingly, individuals who are high on MD can be said to have low integrity and vice-versa. This is relevant as measures of integrity have been shown to negatively relate to CWBs (Ones et al., 1993; Van Iddekinge et al., 2012), in turn suggesting the likelihood of a positive relationship between MD and CWBs. More directly, various authors have explicitly argued that MD is relevant for understanding unethical behavior (Moore, 2008; Treviño et al., 2014). Simply put, when faced with the prospect of an unethical or inappropriate act that would nonetheless be personally beneficial (i.e., lying to one's employer to get time off work), MD can facilitate the occurrence of that behavior by deactivating relevant moral and ethical standards so that the behavior can be enacted without feeling guilty. Consistent with this, prior empirical work has shown that MD is associated with various forms of CWBs (Detert et al., 2008; Moore et al., 2012). Thus, CWBs represent an important criterion domain to be predicted by MD.

Beyond serving as a criterion for prediction, an understanding of CWBs has additional relevance for the development of an SJT focused on MD. The creation of an SJT necessitates careful consideration of appropriate scenario content. More specifically, scenario content should reflect situations that are germane to the focal construct to be assessed. In this regard, CWBs provide a highly effective situational context within which to assess the propensity for MD, as these situations directly provide the *opportunity for MD*.[2] Importantly, the inclusion of CWB descriptions in the SJT does not mean that the SJT measures the actual enactment of CWBs (which represents the criterion of prediction), but rather CWB-focused scenarios provide a relevant situational context within which the focal construct of MD can be assessed. This, in turn, has the benefit of increasing specificity and fidelity regarding the domain in which the assessment is intended to be used (i.e., the workplace). This matter, along with other design features of the current SJT, are discussed further in the following section.

4 | OVERVIEW OF SJTS AND THE CURRENT STUDY

As a method of measurement, SJTs typically present respondents with a series of situational scenarios, and respondents are asked to provide ratings of some kind pertaining to the situation in question (Arthur et al., 2014). Although tests of this nature have a long history, Motowidlo et al. (1990) are often credited for reinvigorating interest in this measurement approach for industrial-organizational psychology (Lievens & Motowidlo, 2016). Given growing interest in this topic, there have been numerous thoughtful and comprehensive reviews of the SJT literature (Campion et al., 2014; Christian et al., 2010; Lievens & Motowidlo, 2016; McDaniel et al., 2001, 2007; McDaniel & Nguyen, 2001; Weekly & Ployhart, 2006; Whetzel & McDaniel, 2009). Our goal is not to provide a complete review here, but rather to highlight several pertinent matters.

As with any method of measurement, SJTs have associated strengths and limitations. A primary appeal of such measures comes from evidence supporting their capacity to predict important workplace criteria (McDaniel et al., 2001). In addition, SJTs have been shown to have incremental validity above that of other common predictors (Clevenger et al., 2001). Research has also shown SJTs to be potentially less susceptible to faking than Likert-based scales (Kasten et al., 2018). Such evidence notwithstanding, a prominent concern in the literature is lack of clarity regarding the nature of constructs assessed by SJTs and corresponding theoretical confusion about the mechanisms that account for their predictive capacity. Situational judgment tests have been shown to capture aspects of cognitive ability and personality to varying degrees (McDaniel et al., 2007) along with various other potential constructs domains (Christian et al., 2010). Others have drawn on the principle of behavioral consistency to argue that SJTs are effective because the behaviors depicted in test scenarios and response options represent a low-fidelity simulation that corresponds to important on-the-job behaviors (Motowidlo et al., 1990). Recent work has also argued that SJT scores might largely be a function of implicit personality theories or general domain knowledge (Lievens & Motowidlo, 2016).

Perhaps in response to this state of confusion, a growing number of efforts have been made to develop SJTs that directly target a particular construct of interest, such as personal initiative (Bledow & Frese, 2009), leadership (Peus et al., 2013), or team role knowledge (Mumford et al., 2008). In these latter examples of construct-focused SJTs, the construct in question is made explicitly clear, and the theoretical basis for expecting relations with criteria is derived from theory underlying the focal construct. We contribute to this area by offering a new SJT explicitly developed to measure the propensity for MD in relation to work. Ultimately, SJTs can be described in terms of various design features (Arthur et al., 2014; Campion et al., 2014), so it becomes critically important that design choices are made with consideration for the focal construct to be measured. In what follows, we highlight important design features of the MD-SJT with a focus on optimizing valid and reliable measurement. To provide context for this discussion, an example item is shown in Figure 1.

4.1 | SJT design features

A critical starting point for any SJT is to consider the approach for generating scenario stems and response statements. Our guiding principle in this regard was to maximize evidence for validity based on test content—or substantive conceptual overlap between test content and the construct domain(s) of interest. There is often an unrecognized duality of focus in discussions of content validity, where some place primary emphasis on content overlap with the performance/criterion domain (Binning & Barrett, 1989), whereas others speak of content overlap with the focal construct to be measured

Instructions to Respondents

People at work often face situations that have no 'right' answer or clear solution. On the following pages are various scenarios people may encounter at work. Each scenario includes several statements about the situation. Please read each scenario and provide your opinion regarding the statements about the scenario.

Example Scenario Stem

An employee has just completed a form at work that summarizes their department's productivity for the month. The department supervisor asks the employee to make a change to the form that will make the department look more productive. The change appears to be relatively minor, but is also a false representation of the department's productivity. [Misuse of Information]

Example Response Statements

- The employee should make the change because the supervisor told them to. [Displacement of Responsibility]
- Its alright to fudge the details a little to help the department run smoothly. [Euphemistic Labeling]
- Good employees do what is best for their department, so making the change is the right thing to do. [Moral Justification]
- Since the change is relatively minor, making this change is not a big deal. [Distortion of Consequences]

Response Scale for Statements

1	2	3	4	5	6
Strongly Disagree	Moderately Disagree	Slightly Disagree	Slightly Agree	Moderately Agree	Strongly Agree

FIGURE 1 Example moral disengagement-situational judgment test (MD-SJT) Scenario Stem and Response Statements. These examples are not included in the final version of the SJT

(Haynes et al., 1995). It can be argued that SJTs are uniquely suited to address both instantiations of content validity, as scenarios can be written to capture the performance/criterion domain and response statements can be written to capture the focal construct to be measured. Accordingly, for the MD-SJT, the scenarios were explicitly written to implicate behaviors from the CWB categories outlined in Table 2 as a means of eliciting MD rationalizations. The response statements, in contrast, were explicitly written to implicate rationalizations for the scenario behaviors based on the MD mechanisms outlined in Table 1. As noted previously, the inclusion of CWB descriptions in the SJT scenarios does not mean that the SJT measures the actual enactment of CWBs, but rather CWB-focused scenarios provide a relevant situational context within which the focal construct of MD can be assessed. More specifically, situations implicating CWBs provide the opportunity for MD to be expressed by respondents through their judgment about the situations.

It is also important to consider instructions for test-takers and the associated response format. For the MD-SJT, respondents are instructed to provide their opinion regarding each response statement on a 6-point scale (1 = *Strongly Disagree* and 6 = *Strongly Agree*). Two matters are relevant here. First, SJT instructions have traditionally been either knowledge-focused, where respondents are asked what the best response is, or behavioral tendency-focused, where respondents are asked what they would most likely do (McDaniel et al., 2007). These instructional approaches have recently come under criticism, as they focus on response option effectiveness as opposed to 'judgement of the situation per se' (Lievens & Motowidlo, 2016; p. 11). Indeed, Lievens and Motowidlo (2016) concluded that this calls into question 'the extent to which existing traditional SJTs are measures of situational judgment' (pp. 11–12). For the MD-SJT, however, response ratings would reflect a direct judgment about the behavior implicated within the situational scenario

(as a means of measuring MD), thus potentially providing a more genuine example of situational judgment. Second, this response format can be described as a rate-all format in which test-takers provide a rating for all response statements, as compared to alternatives such as ranking response options or selecting the best/worst. This was an appropriate choice for the current SJT, as all response statements were written to be reflective of the same underlying construct. Correspondingly, when scores are averaged across all response statements, higher scores represent a greater endorsement of various rationalization mechanisms, thus indicating a greater propensity for MD. Research has shown that compared to other response formats, the rate-all approach is associated with improved convergent validity with theoretically related personality variables, reduced adverse impact against minority test-takers, and improved internal consistency reliability (Arthur et al., 2014).

Another important consideration is how best to minimize the potential for socially desirable responding and related threats to validity (Furr, 2018; Podsakoff et al., 2003). Two design features were included with this mind. First, the scenarios were written from a third-person perspective to reduce the likelihood of inauthentic responding motivated by a desire to avoid self-incrimination. In other words, the psychological distance afforded by the third-person perspective, as compared to the first-person perspective, was deemed useful for minimizing the automatic activation of impression management processes. Second, a bogus non-CWB scenario was added to the beginning of the test, which described a supervisor's request for employees to work extra hours on an urgent project. The inclusion of this bogus scenario, which has an opposite valence compared to the operational CWB-focused scenarios, was aimed at reducing the potential for automatic or pattern-based responding at one end of the response scale. Taken together, the design features described in this section were thoughtfully and intentionally chosen in service of creating a valid and reliable SJT for measuring MD.

4.2 | Validity evidence based on association with other variables

Beyond design features, a critical source of validity evidence comes from an examination of associations with other variables (American Educational Research Association, American Psychological Association, & National Council on Measurement in Education, 2014; Society for Industrial & Organizational Psychology, 2003). This encompasses what has traditionally been described as convergent and discriminant validity evidence as well as criterion-related validity evidence (Binning & Barrett, 1989). Given that the MD-SJT was created to measure the construct of MD, supportive validity evidence can be found by examining convergence with an established measure of this construct (i.e., the Moore MD measure).

Hypothesis 1 *The MD-SJT will be positively related to the Moore MD measure.*

Regarding criterion-related validity, the discussion of MD above—along with evidence from the literature (Detert et al., 2008; Moore et al., 2012; Treviño et al., 2014)—clearly positions CWBs as an important criterion to be predicted. Accordingly, additional evidence for validity can be found in an examination of whether the MD-SJT is associated with CWBs.

Hypothesis 2 *The MD-SJT will be positively related to CWBs.*

As an extension of Hypothesis 2, research in the area of personality testing has shown that contextualized personality scales can account for incremental variance in criteria of interest above that of general-focused personality scales (Bing et al., 2004). This has relevance for the current study in that the SJT format, which allows for the use of detailed and work-focused scenarios, may similarly allow for incremental prediction of CWBs above the Moore MD measure, which was developed as a general-focused scale.

Hypothesis 3 *The MD-SJT will account for incremental variance in CWBs beyond that accounted for by the Moore MD measure.*

Given that the MD-SJT includes various scenarios that focus on different categories of CWBs, an interesting possibility is that the prediction of CWBs might be maximized by aligning specific scenario topics with related CWB criterion content. For example, if one is specifically interested in predicting theft, it may be beneficial to focus exclusively on those SJT scenarios that implicate theft and related behavior. This is consistent with the notion that criterion-related validity can be improved when there is a meaningful alignment between predictors and criteria (Bartram, 2005; also see Schmitt et al., 2003).

Hypothesis 4 *Prediction of CWBs will be maximized if the MD-SJT scenario topics are aligned with CWB criterion content.*

Additional convergent validity evidence can be garnered by examining associations with other variables within the focal variable's nomological network (Cronbach & Meehl, 1955). As described above, MD consists of rationalization mechanisms to avoid guilt surrounding unethical or inappropriate behavior. Based on this understanding of MD, ties to personality variables become apparent when considering various dimensions of the Big Five (Costa & McCrae, 1992). The personality trait of conscientiousness includes elements of self-discipline, dutifulness, and order. An employee high on this trait would focus on the maintenance of a path, feel a sense of accountability to themselves and the organization, and feel an appreciation for rules and guidelines, all of which are in contrast to the disregard for moral and ethical standards evident in MD. Similarly antithetical to MD is agreeableness, which includes facets such as altruism and trust. In potential opposition to MD, these features of agreeableness indicate an avoidance of dishonesty/deceit. Lastly, neuroticism, which includes elements of impulsivity, anxiety, and self-consciousness, may relate to an increased use of MD

rationalizations, as such rationalizations serve to reduce anxiety surrounding inappropriate behaviors. Beyond this, there is empirical evidence that supports moderate correlations of MD with conscientiousness, agreeableness, and neuroticism (Egan et al., 2015; Kish-Gephart et al., 2014; Ogunfowora & Bourdage, 2014; Zhou et al., 2018). Conscientiousness, agreeableness, and neuroticism have also been consistently shown to correlate with measures of both integrity (Marcus et al., 2007) and CWBs (Berry et al., 2007). The above arguments and empirical evidence provide support for the following hypothesis.

Hypothesis 5 *The MD-SJT will be (a) negatively related to conscientiousness, (b) negatively related to agreeableness, and (c) positively related to neuroticism.*

For discriminant validity, data were collected with a measure of artistic interest, for which we had no a priori reason to expect an association with the MD-SJT. The inclusion of such a variable is also potentially valuable as a marker for method bias, where a marker variable is one that is theoretically unrelated to the constructs of interest (Podsakoff et al., 2003). It is difficult to identify an exact magnitude of correlation that constitutes evidence for discriminant validity, so it is useful to consider discriminant correlations in relation to other correlations to see if the overall pattern is logically coherent (Furr, 2018).

Hypothesis 6 *The magnitude of the association between the MD-SJT and artistic interest will be lower than that between the MD-SJT and hypothesized variables (i.e., Moore MD measure, CWBs, conscientiousness, agreeableness, and neuroticism).*

Lastly, a potential criticism that can be made of the MD-SJT relates to the scenarios being written from a third-person perspective (see Figure 1). Although this was intentionally done to minimize the potential for socially desirable responding, it could be argued that this perspective reduces the conceptual link between test-takers responses and their own behavioral inclinations. To address this concern, data were collected using a measure of *behavioral inclination* capturing the likelihood of test-takers themselves engaging in the behaviors described in the MD-SJT scenarios. The rationale was that those who endorse MD rationalization mechanisms for inappropriate conduct (as captured in the MD-SJT) are de facto indicating that they view such conduct as non-problematic, in turn suggesting an increased likelihood of personally engaging in that conduct. Put another way, behavioral inclination might be seen as an alternative or proxy criterion that could be positioned as an intermediary variable between MD propensity and CWB enactment. Someone high on MD propensity would be more likely to view inappropriate behavior as non-problematic, in turn resulting in a higher behavioral inclination for engaging in that behavior, which then might result in the actual enactment of that behavior. This is consistent with the theory of planned behavior, which suggests that an individual's attitude toward a behavior is an important precursor for behavioral intentions and the ultimate enactment of the behavior (Ajzen, 1991; Chang, 1998).

Hypothesis 7 *The MD-SJT will be positively related to a measure of behavioral inclination reflecting the likelihood of engaging in the behaviors described in the SJT.*

5 | METHOD

The development and validation of the MD-SJT involved two independent rounds of subject-matter expert (SME) review and data collected from three independent samples. In this section, we begin by describing the development of the MD-SJT, which includes discussion of SME review. This is followed by sub-sections pertaining to participants, procedures, and measures for the three samples involved in data collection. To avoid redundancy, we describe information for all three samples within each sub-section, rather than repeating the sub-sections for each of the three samples. In doing so, we note important differences between the samples as needed (e.g., not every measure was used in each sample to avoid over-burdening participants).

5.1 | SJT development

The development procedure was an iterative process that can be summarized in three stages: writing of test content, SME review, and refinement of test content.

5.1.1 | Writing of test content

To begin, an initial pool of 47 scenarios stems were generated along with 282 response statements (6 per scenario). Regarding scenario generation, several guiding criteria were used. First, as noted previously, the scenarios had to implicate a behavior that was reflective of a CWB category outlined in Table 2. Second, the behavior and surrounding situation had to be applicable to commonly recognized jobs so as to be relatable to respondents. Third, the implicated behavior had to be inappropriate or unethical but simultaneously allow for the possibility of compelling rationalizations. Lastly, the target length for the scenarios was three to five sentences using clear and simple language. For response statement generation, several additional guiding criteria were used. First, as described above, each response had to implicate a potential rationalization for the associated scenario behavior based on the MD mechanisms outlined in Table 1. Second, the responses were not to introduce any new information beyond what was already included in the stem. Finally, the target length for the response statements was one to two sentences with the goal of capturing the rationalization in a single succinct sentence.

5.1.2 | SME review

Following the generation of scenarios stems and response statements, the test content was subjected to two independent rounds of SME review.[3] For the first round of review, SMEs provided several ratings regarding the stem scenarios and responses statements. Regarding stem scenarios, SMEs first indicated whether the 'behavior implicated in the scenario [is] a counter-productive work behavior (CWB)' using a 4-point scale (1 = *Definitely No* and 4 = *Definitely Yes*). Then, the SMEs were asked to categorize the behavior from the scenario into one of the CWB categories shown in Table 2. Regarding response statements, SMEs indicated whether the 'statement [is] a rationalization that someone might use to justify the implicated behavior' using a 4-point scale (1 = *Definitely No* and 4 = *Definitely Yes*). Then, as before, the SMEs were asked to categorize the rationalization statements into one of the MD categories shown in Table 1. Lastly, to ensure clarity of test content, SME were asked to rate both the scenario stems and response statements in terms of whether they were 'easy to understand' using a 4-point scale (1 = *Very Difficult to Understand* and 4 = *Very Easy to Understand*). In all cases, the SMEs were given the option of indicating that they were 'unsure or unable' to make a rating/categorization. For the second round of review, SMEs provided the same ratings as in the first round with two exceptions. First, the categorization questions (i.e., CWB categories and MD categories) were not included. Second, to ensure credibility of test content, SME were asked to rate both the stem scenarios and responses statements in terms of whether they were 'believable' using a using a 4-point scale (1 = *Very Unbelievable* and 4 = *Very Believable*).

5.1.3 | Refinement of test content

After the first round of SME review, 20 scenario stems and their associated response statements were removed along with an additional response statement from all remaining scenarios. Minor editing was also conducted. After the second round of SME review, eight more scenario stems and their associated response statements were removed along with an additional response statement from all remaining scenarios. Ultimately, the SME review and corresponding refinement of test content resulted in a final set of 19 scenario stems and 76 response statements (4 per scenario). A summary of the SME ratings focusing on the final test content is shown in Table 3. Collectively, these ratings provide evidence of validity based on test content, as the ratings substantiated linkages of the scenario stems and response statements with the CWB and MD construct domains, respectively.

5.2 | Participants and procedure

Following the development of the SJT, data were collected from three independent samples to examine test reliability and gather further validity evidence. The first sample (hereafter, sample 1) was recruited using Amazon Mechanical Turk. Participants in this sample

TABLE 3 Summary of subject matter expert (SME) ratings of test content

Rating	Round 1 of review	Round 2 of review
"Is the behavior implicated in the scenario a counter-productive work behavior (CWB)?" (1 = Definitely No, 4 = Definitely Yes)	*M* = 3.81 *SD* = 0.19	*M* = 3.62 *SD* = 0.29
"Is the response statement a rationalization that someone might use to justify the implicated behavior?" (1 = Definitely No, 4 = Definitely Yes)	*M* = 3.66 *SD* = 0.27	*M* = 3.61 *SD* = 0.22
"How would you categorize the behavior implicated in the scenario?" (Results reported as number of scenarios for each category)[a]	Theft or Related Behavior (2) Alcohol or Drug Use (0) Destruction of Property (2) Misuse of Information (2) Misuse of Time or Resources (2) Interpersonal Misconduct[b] (3) Poor Quality Work (3) Unsafe Behavior (3) Poor Attendance (2)	*N/A*
"How would you categorize the response statement?" (Results reported as number of response statements for each category)[a]	Moral Justification (20) Euphemistic Labeling (2) Advantageous Comparison (6) Displacement of Responsibility (4) Diffusion of Responsibility (12) Distortion of Consequences (15) Dehumanization (2) Attribution of Blame (9) Tie between two categories (5) Most SMEs indicated "unsure" (1)	*N/A*
"Is the scenario/response statement easy to understand?" (1 = Very Difficult to Understand, 4 = Very Easy to Understand)	*M* = 3.95 *SD* = 0.11	*M* = 3.95 *SD* = 0.10
"Is the scenario/response statement believable?" (1 = Very Believable, 4 = Very Unbelievable)	*N/A*	*M* = 3.75 *SD* = 0.22

Note.: Results are reported for the final set of 19 scenario stems and 76 response statements. There were five SMEs for the first round of review and 11 for the second.

[a]Category labels for each scenario and response statement were assigned based on the most frequent category chosen by SMEs.

[b]During SME review, this category was labelled as "incivility."

were compensated in the amount $0.25 along with a $2.75 completion bonus (total = $3.00). The second sample (hereafter, sample 2) was recruited using Qualtrics Panel services. Qualtrics enlists survey participants from various sources where participants are compensated an amount agreed upon with Qualtrics prior to beginning the survey. The third sample (hereafter, sample 3) was recruited using a snowball strategy where the authors requested participation from students, colleagues, and acquaintances, who in turn were asked to request participation from others. Participants in sample 3 were given the opportunity to enter a lottery for a $100 Amazon gift card. For all three samples, being 18 years of age and currently employed were eligibility requirements. All participants were ensured that their responses would be anonymous. Following the identification and removal of careless or insufficient effort responders,[4] sample sizes were 294, 339, and 91 for samples 1–3, respectively. A summary of demographic information for participants is shown in Table 4. Institutional Review Board (IRB) approval was acquired for the protocols in all three samples, and all participants consented to participate.

5.3 | Measures

The order of study measures (and of items within measures) was randomized such that each participant responded to the measures/items in a different random order.

5.3.1 | SJT (all samples)

The final version of the SJT included 19 scenario stems and 76 response statements. Each response statement represented a MD mechanism that could be used to justify a CWB described in the corresponding scenario (see Figure 1). Respondents were asked to rate each response statement on a 6-point scale (1 = *Strongly Disagree* and 6 = *Strongly Agree*). A total scale score was derived by averaging responses to all 76 statements, with a higher score indicating a greater propensity for MD. Internal consistency reliability values were 0.97, 0.99, and 0.96 for samples 1–3, respectively. In addition, because the scenario stems depicted different types of CWBs (see Table 2), it was possible to calculate scores for select scenarios that focus on specific categories of CWBs. This allowed for an examination of whether the prediction of CWBs (as a criterion variable) could be improved by aligning specific SJT scenario topics with corresponding CWB criterion content. Accordingly, scores were calculated in samples 1 and 2 for the following scenario topics: theft or related behavior; destruction of property; misuse of information; misuse of time or resources; interpersonal misconduct; poor quality work; unsafe behavior; and poor attendance. This was accomplished by averaging scores for only those response statements that were linked to scenarios that focused on the particular topic in question. Support for this approach was provided by exploratory and confirmatory factor analyses described below. Internal consistency reliability values ranged from 0.88 to 0.96 across both samples.

5.3.2 | CWBs (samples 1 and 2)

In order to maximize coverage of the CWB criterion domain, items from two scales (Bennett & Robinson, 2000; Gruys & Sackett, 2003) were combined to form an overall CWB measure. To effectively integrate these measures, several items were deleted or merged to avoid redundancy, and the wording of some items was slightly modified to ensure consistency in framing. In total, 66 items were used to measure CWBs. Participants were instructed to indicate 'the extent to which you have engaged in the following behaviors at work'. An example item states, 'Taken cash or property belonging to the company'. Responses were made on a 7-point frequency scale (1 = *Never* and 7 = *Daily*). A total scale score was derived by averaging responses to all 66 items, with a higher score indicating a greater amount of CWBs. Internal consistency reliability values were 0.95 and 0.99 for samples 1 and 2, respectively. As with the MD-SJT, it was possible to calculate scores that focus on specific categories of CWBs. Accordingly, scores were calculated for the following CWB criterion categories: theft or related behavior; destruction of property[5]; misuse of information; misuse of time or resources; interpersonal misconduct; poor quality work; unsafe behavior; and poor attendance. This was accomplished by averaging scores for only those items that were relevant to the particular category in question.[6] Internal consistency reliability values ranged from 0.70 to 0.96.

5.3.3 | Personality measures (sample 1)

Items from the International Personality Item Pool (http://ipip.ori.org/; also see Goldberg et al., 2006) were used to measure the following personality dimensions: conscientiousness; agreeableness; neuroticism; extraversion; and openness. In some cases, items were slightly modified to avoid ambiguous or colloquial language (e.g., 'Often feel blue' was changed to 'Often feel sad'). In total, there were 50 items, some of which were reverse-coded, with 10 items per dimension. Participants were instructed to indicate 'how accurately the following statements describe you'. An example item for conscientiousness states, 'Pay attention to details'. Responses were made on a 5-point scale (1 = *Very Inaccurate* and 5 = *Very Accurate*). A total scale score was derived by averaging responses to all 10 items per dimension, with a higher score reflecting a higher level of the trait in question. Internal consistency reliability values were 0.87 (conscientiousness), 0.82 (agreeableness), 0.89 (neuroticism), 0.89 (extraversion), and 0.81 (openness).

5.3.4 | Moore MD measure (sample 2)

This measure, developed by Moore et al. (2012), includes eight items that reflect various MD mechanisms. Participants were instructed to indicate 'whether or not you agree with the following statements'. An example item states, 'It is okay to spread rumors to defend those you care about'. Responses were made on a 7-point

TABLE 4 Summary of participant demographic information (All Samples)

Demographic characteristic	Sample 1 ($n = 294$)	Sample 2 ($n = 339$)	Sample 3 ($n = 91$)
Employment status			
Full-time	97.96%	100.00%	70.33%
Part-time	2.04%	0.00%	29.67%
Job level			
Hourly-paid worker	46.94%	50.44%	40.66%
Salaried worker	42.18%	27.14%	39.56%
First-level manager	6.12%	7.37%	8.79%
Second-level manager	3.74%	5.31%	4.40%
Executive-level manager	0.34%	6.19%	3.30%
Other/missing	0.68%	3.54%	3.30%
Industry			
Accommodation/food services	2.72%	4.72%	1.10%
Administrative/support services	4.08%	3.24%	3.30%
Agriculture/forestry/fishing/hunting	0.68%	0.29%	0.00%
Arts/entertainment/recreation	4.76%	1.77%	6.59%
Construction	3.06%	7.37%	0.00%
Educational services	13.95%	7.37%	35.16%
Finance/insurance	8.50%	6.49%	4.40%
Government	5.78%	5.31%	5.49%
Health care/social assistance	14.97%	8.55%	9.89%
Information services/data technology	6.12%	10.91%	4.40%
Management of companies/enterprises	1.02%	0.88%	1.10%
Manufacturing	5.44%	8.26%	1.10%
Mining/quarrying/oil/gas extraction	0.68%	0.00%	0.00%
Professional/scientific/technical	8.50%	1.77%	5.49%
Real estate/rental/leasing	2.38%	1.47%	1.10%
Retail/sales	11.56%	12.39%	6.59%
Transportation/warehousing	1.70%	3.83%	0.00%
Utilities	0.00%	0.59%	1.10%
Waste management/remediation	0.68%	0.00%	1.10%
Wholesale trade	0.68%	1.47%	0.00%
Other/missing	2.72%	13.27%	12.09%
Race			
African American/black	8.16%	10.91%	3.30%
American Indian/Alaska native	0.34%	0.29%	2.20%
Asian/Pacific Islander	7.82%	8.85%	2.20%
Caucasian/white	78.91%	46.61%	82.42%
Hispanic/latino	3.06%	30.97%	9.89%
Other/missing	1.70%	2.36%	0.00%
Gender			
Female	57.14%	61.95%	73.63%
Male	42.86%	37.76%	26.37%
Other/missing	0.00%	0.29%	0.00%
Age	$M = 38.31$ $SD = 10.49$	$M = 39.00$ $SD = 13.18$	$M = 31.82$ $SD = 12.33$

scale (1 = *Strongly Disagree* and 7 = *Strongly Agree*). A total scale score was derived by averaging responses to all items, with a higher score reflecting a higher propensity for MD. Internal consistency reliability was 0.94.

5.3.5 | Artistic interest (sample 2)

This variable was also measured with items from the International Personality Item Pool. There were 10 items, some of which were reverse-coded. Participants were instructed to indicate 'how accurately the following statements describe you'. An example item states, 'Believe in the importance of art'. Responses were made on a 5-point scale (1 = *Very Inaccurate* and 5 = *Very Accurate*). A total scale score was derived by averaging responses to all items, with a higher score reflecting a higher level of artistic interest. Internal consistency reliability was 0.81.

5.3.6 | Behavioral inclination (sample 3)

This variable was measured by including the following question after each MD-SJT scenario in sample 3: 'If you were in a similar situation, would you engage in this behavior?'. Given that there were 19 scenarios, this question was asked 19 times. Responses were made on a 7-point scale (1 = *Definitely No—there is a 0% chance* and 7 = *Definitely Yes—there is a 100% chance*). A total scale score was derived by averaging responses to all 19 instances of this question, with a higher score reflecting a greater personal likelihood of engaging in the behaviors described in the MD-SJT. Internal consistency reliability was 0.87.

6 | RESULTS

6.1 | Dimensionality of the MD-SJT

First, a series of exploratory factor analyses were conducted in sample 1 to determine whether item responses were unidimensional within each of the 19 scenarios. Results based on principal axis factoring revealed a single factor for all scenarios, as in all cases there was a single factor extracted with an eigenvalue greater than one. Percentage of variance accounted for by the single factor ranged from 61.79% to 87.34% across the scenarios (mean = 72.64%). An additional exploratory factor analysis of all items from all scenarios combined showed that items clustered primarily by scenario.[7] This finding can be seen as consistent with Trait Activation Theory (Tett & Burnett, 2003; Tett et al., 2013), which highlights the importance of situational features in eliciting psychological trait expression. That is, even if unidimensional, it is conceivable that the expression of MD is contingent on the situation in question. In line with this reasoning, the exploratory factor analysis results showed that MD-SJT item responses clustered by scenarios and were internally consistent within the scenarios.

Second, following the exploratory results from sample 1, a confirmatory factor analysis was conducted in sample 2, in which scenario scores (i.e., items averaged within a scenario) were used as manifest indicators in a two-tier hierarchical model, as shown in Figure 2. This model specified eight first-order factors, each reflecting the

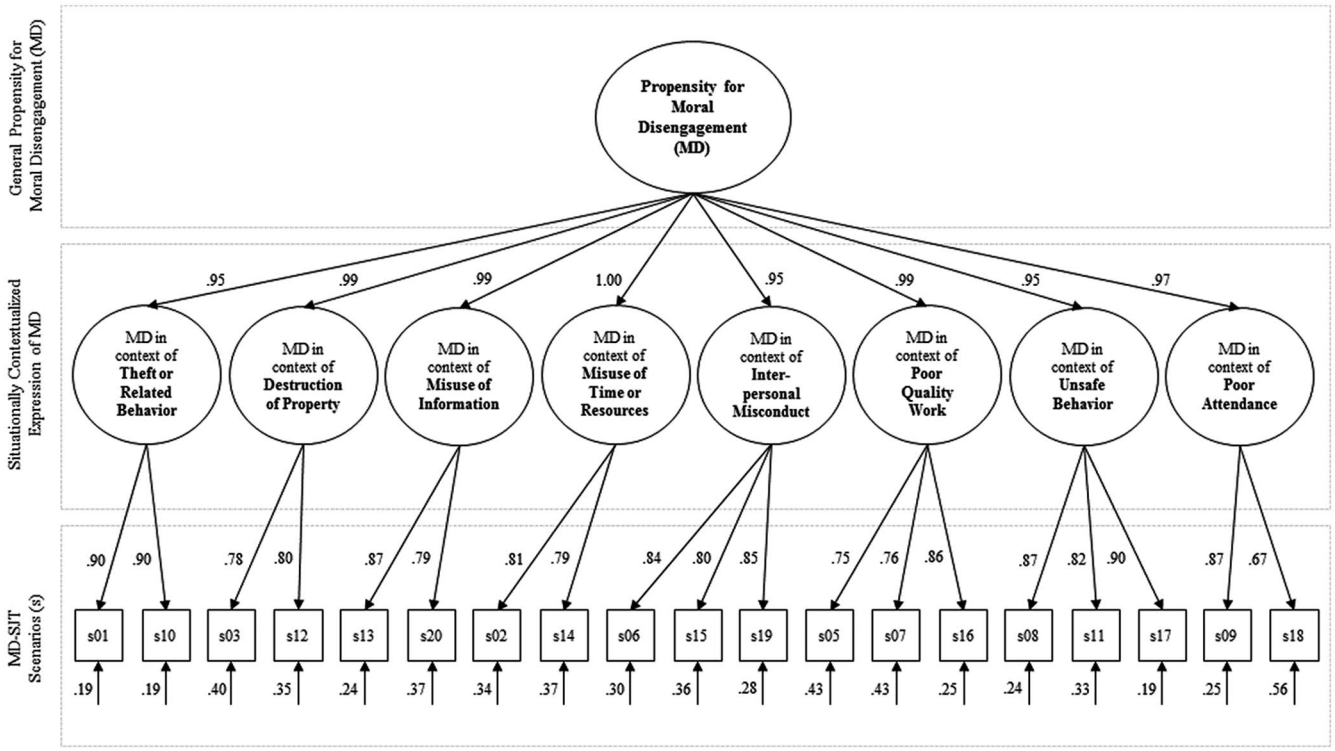


FIGURE 2 Confirmatory factor analysis of MD-SJT scenarios in sample 2. Numerical values represent standardized model results

TABLE 5 Descriptive statistics and correlations (all samples)

Sample/variable	*M*	*SD*	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Sample 1									
1. MD-SJT total	2.32	0.82	(0.97)						
2. CWB total	1.63	0.56	0.48**	(0.95)					
3. Conscientiousness	4.11	0.66	−0.32**	−0.38**	(0.87)				
4. Agreeableness	4.02	0.61	−0.37**	−0.38**	0.49**	(0.82)			
5. Neuroticism	2.35	0.84	0.19**	0.21**	−0.55**	−0.48**	(0.89)		
6. Extraversion	3.13	0.87	−0.15**	−0.13*	0.35**	0.40**	−0.46**	(0.89)	
7. Openness	3.76	0.74	−0.10	−0.08	0.20**	0.29**	−0.23**	0.38**	(0.81)
Sample 2									
1. MD-SJT total	2.62	1.24	(0.99)						
2. CWB total	1.81	1.18	0.58**	(0.99)					
3. Moore MD Measure	2.53	1.55	0.81**	0.65**	(0.94)				
4. Artistic interest	3.84	0.75	−0.23**	−0.25**	−0.33**	(0.81)			
Sample 3									
1. MD-SJT total	2.21	0.65	(0.96)						
2. Behavioral inclination	2.33	0.83	0.91**	(0.87)					

Note.: For sample 1, $n = 294$. For sample 2, due to listwise deletion of cases with missing data, n ranges from 328–339. For sample 3, due to listwise deletion of cases with missing data, $n = 90$. Internal consistency reliability (alpha) values are presented in parentheses along the diagonal.

Abbreviations: CWB, Counterproductive work behaviors; MD, Moral disengagement; SJT, Situational judgment test.

*$p < .05$.

**$p < .01$.

situationally contextualized expression of MD in relation to a particular type of CWB (e.g., MD in the context of theft or related behavior). In addition, these eight first-order factors were modeled as indicators of a second-order factor reflecting a general underlying propensity for MD. Results based on robust maximum likelihood estimation indicated reasonable fit for the model shown in Figure 2 ($\chi^2[145] = 335.77$, $p < .01$; CFI = 0.95, TLI = 0.94; SRMR = 0.04).[8] These results provide provisional support for our approach of considering both an overall average score on the MD-SJT as well as category scores that correspond to different types of CWBs.

6.2 | Hypothesis testing

Descriptive statistics and correlations for all variables and samples are shown in Table 5. Hypothesis 1 suggested that the MD-SJT would be positively related to the Moore MD measure. This hypothesis was tested in sample 2. As can be seen in Table 5, there was a positive and statistically significant relationship between these two variables ($r = .81$, $p < .01$). The magnitude of this correlation, which represents a large effect size (Cohen, 1992), supports the contention that the MD-SJT substantively captures the construct of MD. Thus, Hypothesis 1 was supported.

Hypothesis 2 suggested that the MD-SJT would be positively related to CWBs. As can be seen in Table 5, there was a positive and statistically significant relationship between the MD-SJT and the total CWB measure in both sample 1 ($r = .48$, $p < .01$) and sample 2 ($r = .58$, $p < .01$). These results suggest that scores on the MD-SJT can be used to predict the occurrence of CWBs. Thus, Hypothesis 2 was supported. As an extension of this finding, Hypothesis 3 suggested that the MD-SJT would account for incremental variance in CWBs beyond that accounted for by the Moore MD measure. Results are shown in Table 6, which presents hierarchical regression analyses predicting the total CWB measure in sample 2. Note that artistic interest was included in this regression as a potential marker for method bias. As can be seen in Step 2 of the regression, the MD-SJT remained a significant predictor after controlling for artistic interest and the Moore MD measure, accounting for slight but statistically significant incremental variance in CWBs ($\Delta R^2 = .01$, $p < .05$). There were no substantive differences in a trimmed model that excluded artistic interest. Based on these findings, Hypothesis 3 was supported.

Hypothesis 4 suggested that the prediction of CWBs would be maximized if the MD-SJT scenario topics were aligned with CWB criterion content. This was tested by calculating SJT and CWB scores that focused on similar themes (see description under measures above). Results are shown in Table 7 (sample 1) and Table 8 (sample 2), which present aligned correlations between MD-SJT scenario topics and CWB criterion content. The results were not supportive of Hypothesis 4, as there were only one instance where the aligned correlation was the largest magnitude correlation for the particular CWB outcome in question (i.e., unsafe behavior in sample 2). Nonetheless, is worth noting that all of the SJT scenario topic scores exhibited high reliability and were significantly

TABLE 6 Hierarchical regression analyses predicting CWB total (sample 2)

	Step 1		Step 2		Trimmed Model	
Variable	***β***	***t***	***β***	***t***	***β***	***t***
Artistic interest	−.03	−0.64	−.04	−0.79		
Moore MD measure	.64	14.29**	0.51	6.94**	.52	7.40**
MD-SJT total			0.16	2.27*	.16	2.23*
R^2=	.42		0.43		.43	
F=	119.77	**	82.58	**	123.71	**
ΔR^2=	—		0.01		—	
Δ*F*=	—		5.16	*	—	

Note.: Due to listwise deletion of cases with missing data, $n = 328$.

Abbreviations: CWB, Counterproductive work behaviors; MD, Moral disengagement. SJT, Situational judgment test.

*$p < .05$.

**$p < .01$.

predictive of all CWB outcome scores. Despite this, Hypothesis 4 was not supported. An expanded correlation table with correlations among all SJT and CWB sub-scales in sample 1 and sample 2 can be found in Appendix A.

Hypothesis 5 suggested that the MD-SJT would be (a) negatively related to conscientiousness, (b) negatively related to agreeableness, and (c) positively related to neuroticism. Looking at the results for sample 1 in Table 5, it can be seen that the MD-SJT was negatively related to conscientiousness ($r = -.32$, $p < .01$), negatively related to agreeableness ($r = -.37$, $p < .01$), and positively related to neuroticism ($r = .19$, $p < .01$). The direction and magnitude (representing moderate correlations) of these associations are consistent with previous research (Ogunfowora & Bourdage, 2014; Zhou et al., 2018). Thus, Hypothesis 5 was supported. In addition, although not the focus of a specific hypothesis, measures of extraversion and openness were included for the sake of completeness. It can be seen in Table 5 that correlations of the MD-SJT with extraversion ($r = -.15$, $p < .01$) and openness ($r = -.10$, $p = ns$) were lower in absolute magnitude than the hypothesized personality relationships.

Hypothesis 6 suggested the magnitude of the association between the MD-SJT and artistic interest would be lower than those between the MD-SJT and hypothesized variables (i.e., Moore MD measure, CWBs, conscientiousness, agreeableness, and neuroticism). Looking at sample 2, the correlation between artistic interest and the MD-SJT ($r = -.23$) was lower in magnitude than that of the MD-SJT with both the Moore MD measure ($r = .81$) and the total CWB measure ($r = .58$). A statistical test of the difference between these dependent correlations (Lee & Preacher, 2013; Steiger, 1980) revealed a statically significant difference for both the Moore MD correlation ($z = 9.81$, $p < .01$, one-tailed) and the total CWB correlation ($z = 4.79$, $p < .01$, one-tailed). Comparing the artistic interest correlation (again, $r = -.23$) with hypothesized correlations from sample 1 revealed a larger magnitude correlation of the MD-SJT with the total CWB measure ($r = .48$), conscientiousness ($r = -.32$), and agreeableness ($r = -.37$), but not neuroticism ($r = .19$). A statistical comparison of these independent correlations (using the Fisher r-to-z transformation) revealed significant differences for the CWB correlation ($z = 3.58$, $p < .01$, one-tailed) and the agreeableness correlation ($z = 1.91$, $p < .05$, one-tailed), but not for the conscientiousness or neuroticism correlations. In summary, of the six comparisons made, the differences in magnitude were in the expected direction for five, of which four were statistically significant differences. Thus, Hypothesis 6 was largely (but not exclusively) supported.

Hypothesis 7 suggested that the MD-SJT would be positively related to a measure of behavioral inclination reflecting the likelihood of engaging in the behaviors described in the SJT. As can be seen in Table 5, there was a positive and statistically significant relationship between these two variables in sample 3 ($r = .91$, $p < .01$). The magnitude of this correlation suggests that test-taker responses to the SJT are highly related to the degree to which test-takers would themselves engage in the CWBs depicted. Thus, Hypothesis 7 was supported.

7 | DISCUSSION

The results described herein provide support for the MD-SJT as a reliable and valid SJT for measuring the construct of MD with a focus on the workplace. Across three independent validation samples, the MD-SJT displayed high levels of internal consistency reliability, was strongly related to an established measure of MD, was moderately yet significantly related to hypothesized personality variables, exhibited large effect sizes in the prediction of CWBs, and was incrementally predictive of CWBs above the established measure of MD. Furthermore, to address potential concerns regarding the third-person perspective of the MD-SJT scenarios, it was shown that test-taker responses to the SJT were highly related to the degree to which test-takers reported they would themselves engage in the CWBs depicted. In light of these findings, the MD-SJT appears to be a useful tool for those interested in measuring MD and predicting the occurrence of unethical or inappropriate behaviors in a work context.

TABLE 7 Descriptive statistics and correlations for MD-SJT scenario topics and aligned CWB criterion content (sample 1)

MD-SJT				Aligned CWB criterion content							
				Theft or related behavior	Destruction of property	Misuse of information	Misuse of time or resources	Interpersonal misconduct	Poor quality work	Unsafe behavior	Poor Attendance
			M=	1.23	1.08	1.35	2.47	1.41	1.81	1.31	1.75
			SD=	0.49	0.47	0.62	1.02	0.60	1.03	0.70	0.78
Scenario topic	***M***	***SD***	**α**	**α=**	**0.83**	**0.91**	**0.71**	**0.87**	**0.87**	**0.85**	**0.71**	**0.70**
Theft or related behavior	2.16	1.15	0.92		**0.40****	0.31**	0.37**	0.36**	0.29**	0.40**	0.23**	0.32**
Destruction of property	2.71	1.32	0.92		0.29**	**0.16****	0.25**	0.32**	0.24**	0.30**	0.27**	0.21**
Misuse of information	2.17	1.02	0.88		0.31**	0.29**	**0.33****	0.26**	0.37**	0.32**	0.32**	0.21**
Misuse of time or resources	2.17	1.13	0.91		0.34**	0.26**	0.34**	**0.32****	0.22**	0.34**	0.18**	0.29**
Interpersonal misconduct	2.06	0.92	0.89		0.28**	0.27**	0.24**	0.15*	**0.35****	0.22**	0.22**	0.17**
Poor quality work	2.69	1.09	0.91		0.31**	0.18**	0.27**	0.32**	0.26**	**0.35****	0.22**	0.24**
Unsafe behavior	1.72	0.78	0.91		0.40**	0.39**	0.32**	0.13*	0.35**	0.27**	**0.25****	0.24**
Poor attendance	3.11	1.24	0.90		0.28**	0.14*	0.29**	0.43**	0.24**	0.33**	0.20**	**0.30****

Note.: $n = 294$. Aligned correlations along the diagonal are bolded.

Abbreviations: CWB, Counterproductive work behaviors; MD, Moral disengagement; SJT, Situational judgment test.

*$p < .05$.

**$p < .01$.

TABLE 8 Descriptive statistics and correlations for MD-SJT scenario topics and aligned CWB criterion content (sample 2)

					Aligned CWB criterion content							
					Theft or related behavior	Destruction of property	Misuse of information	Misuse of time or resources	Interpersonal misconduct	Poor quality work	Unsafe behavior	Poor attendance
				M=	1.59	1.52	1.59	2.26	1.80	1.91	1.63	1.92
MD-SJT				*SD*=	1.23	1.23	1.28	1.30	1.26	1.33	1.30	1.27
Scenario topic	***M***	***SD***	**α**	**α=**	**0.96**	**0.92**	**0.95**	**0.93**	**0.96**	**0.92**	**0.89**	**0.89**
Theft or related behavior	2.43	1.48	0.96		**0.58****	0.57**	0.59**	0.48**	0.52**	0.52**	0.54**	0.49**
Destruction of property	2.81	1.43	0.92		0.49**	**0.48****	0.50**	0.42**	0.47**	0.45**	0.46**	0.43**
Misuse of information	2.62	1.39	0.93		0.54**	0.55**	**0.54****	0.41**	0.49**	0.46**	0.52**	0.44**
Misuse of time or resources	2.47	1.42	0.94		0.56**	0.56**	0.56**	**0.45****	0.53**	0.48**	0.54**	0.48**
Interpersonal misconduct	2.57	1.37	0.95		0.54**	0.53**	0.53**	0.39**	**0.52****	0.44**	0.52**	0.45**
Poor quality work	2.84	1.31	0.94		0.52**	0.52**	0.53**	0.42**	0.47**	**0.48****	0.49**	0.45**
Unsafe behavior	2.37	1.39	0.96		0.60**	0.61**	0.59**	0.40**	0.55**	0.49**	**0.59****	0.47**
Poor attendance	3.00	1.35	0.91		0.47**	0.45**	0.48**	0.47**	0.46**	0.47**	0.46**	**0.47****

Note.: Due to listwise deletion of cases with missing data, *n* ranges from 332–339. Aligned correlations along the diagonal are bolded.

Abbreviations: CWB, Counterproductive work behaviors; MD, Moral disengagement; SJT, Situational judgment test.

*$p < .05$.

**$p < .01$.

The development of the MD-SJT benefited from various design features that facilitated the creation of a construct-focused and internally consistent SJT. First, our approach highlighted the value of content validity as a dual-focused lens for SJT development, where scenarios can be explicitly developed to capture the performance/criterion domain of interest, and in contrast, response statements can be explicitly developed to capture the focal construct to be measured. Although this approach may not be entirely novel—as other SJTs have potentially used a similar approach—we believe it is valuable to make such an approach explicit so that it can be intentionally adopted by others. We also utilized various other beneficial design features, such as a rate-all response format that has been shown to improve internal consistency reliability (Arthur et al., 2014; Campion et al., 2014), in addition to consider proactive ways of minimizing socially desirable responding and related threats to validity. As such, the development approach described herein might serve as a useful model for others interested in developing construct-focused and internally consistent SJTs.

It was interesting that Hypothesis 4, regarding improved prediction with alignment of SJT scenario topics and CWB criterion content, was not supported. Upon further consideration, this is not necessarily surprising in light of evidence showing that MD is a robust predictor of various CWBs (Moore et al., 2012), in conjunction with the view of CWB as a reflective construct with a general underlying factor (Marcus et al., 2016). From this perspective, one would expect the propensity for MD to be comparably useful as a predictor of various forms of CWBs. As described by Marcus et al. (2016), 'From a practical point of view, general CWB as a reflective construct implies that interventions that work against one type of CWB would also tend to be effective against any other type of CWB because at least one common cause underlies all CWBs' (p. 208)—where MD is a viable candidate for that underlying common cause. The results shown in Tables 7 and 8 are consistent with this interpretation, as all MD-SJT scenario topic scores exhibited high reliability and were significantly predictive of all CWB outcome scores. A potentially important implication of this finding is that those concerned about test length can still focus on a smaller subset of scenarios, in turn shortening the test while retaining high levels of reliability and predictive validity.

Another finding in need of discussion is the observed correlation between the MD-SJT and artistic interest (Hypothesis 6). The variable of artistic interest was chosen as a means of demonstrating discriminant validity as we had no a priori reason to expect an association with the MD-SJT. Although the correlation between these two variables represented a small effect size, which was smaller in magnitude than most hypothesized relationships, the relationship was statistically significant and thus larger than zero. A likely possibility is that this observed correlation was at least partially a function of common method bias, which has the potential to inflate relationships between variables (Podsakoff et al., 2003). In this regard, the artistic interest variable can be used as a marker for method bias, which can be statistically partialed out of other relationships of interest to determine if those other relationships are purely a function of their common method of measurement. As can be seen in Table 6, controlling for the effect of artistic interest had a negligible impact on the relationship between the MD-SJT and CWBs, suggesting that common method bias was not the primary driver of this crucial association.

Regarding Hypothesis 7, these results provide support for the utility of a third-person perspective in the framing of SJT scenarios. More specifically, the results of Hypothesis 7 showed that SJT responses, based on scenarios written from the third-person perspective, were highly correlated with test-takers admission of whether they themselves would engage in the behaviors implicated in the scenarios. As indicated above, this is consistent with the theory of planned behavior, which suggests that an individual's attitude toward a behavior is an important precursor for behavioral intentions and the ultimate enactment of the behavior (Ajzen, 1991; Chang, 1998). Third person SJT responses can be seen as capturing an evaluation (i.e., attitude) about a behavior described in the scenario, which in turn should be related to one's personal inclination for that behavior, in turn suggesting an association with the actual enactment of that behavior. This line of causal reasoning might be useful to consider when designing the content of SJT scenarios.

7.1 | Limitations and future directions

Despite the benefit of employing three independent samples for data collection, this study relied solely on self-report survey data, which made our results susceptible to common method bias. Indeed, this possibility is suggested in the weak but statistically significant relationship between the MD-SJT and the artistic interest scale, as discussed above. Nonetheless, we believe the data collected allowed for meaningful insight regarding the measurement of MD. First, the analyses shown in Table 6, in which artistic interest served as a marker for method bias, demonstrated that the potential presence of method bias was not sufficient to account for the study findings. Second, it can be argued that self-report data are an advantageous approach for measuring CWBs, considering that many CWBs are only known to those who directly engage in such behaviors. This is consistent with the findings of a meta-analysis conducted by Berry et al. (2012), wherein it was found that 'self-raters reported engaging in more CWB than other-raters reported them engaging in, suggesting other-ratings capture a narrower subset of CWBs' (p. 613). In addition, the anonymity of the data collection protocol likely facilitated honest responding, as compared to a non-anonymous procedure. Third, the replication of the relationship between the MD-SJT and CWBs in multiple independent samples gives further credence to the findings. As another limitation, the various assessments in this study were administered at a single point in time for each sample, precluding the possibility of examining temporal ordering of effects. Ultimately, validation is an on-going process (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014), suggesting that future research can focus on these and other relevant issues.

Building on the limitations noted above, it is useful to consider future directions for research. First, an obvious extension of the

current study would be to examine the MD-SJT in relation to non-self-report measures of CWBs. Although other-report measures have their own limitations (e.g., difficulty of observing the occurrence of CWBs given attempts to conceal such conduct), this would nonetheless serve as additional valuable validity evidence. Second, specific occupations face unique challenges with regard to unethical behavior. For example, the ethical dilemmas faced by police officers (e.g., mistreatment of suspects and intentional mishandling of evidence) are different from those faced by corporate executives (e.g., financial fraud and misleading regulatory agencies). This highlights the importance of examining the MD-SJT in the context of specific occupations. Third, as an extension of the previous points, additional custom items based on the MD-SJT format can be created to directly reflect an occupation of interest. Extending the example of police officers, scenario stems can be written to capture unique situations/CWBs relevant to law enforcement, with response statements representing MD rationalizations for such CWBs. Fourth, it is valuable to recognize the various potential uses of the MD-SJT. Although employee selection is an obvious area of application, this SJT can similarly be used as part of a training needs assessment to determine the need for ethics-based training, or alternatively, as part of training evaluation or employee appraisal to gauge success in promoting an ethical workplace culture. Lastly, other potential issues for future research on the MD-SJT include the collection of more construct validity evidence via an examination of relations with other theoretically relevant variables (e.g., honestly-humility) as well as an assessment of test–retest reliability.

8 | CONCLUSION

Given the adverse consequences of CWBs, it is important to assess predictors of such behaviors. The current study described the development and validation of a SJT focused on the construct of MD, which has been described as 'a uniquely important predictor of a broad range of unethical behaviors' (Moore et al., 2012, p. 3). The results above provide support for the reliability and validity of the SJT, thus advancing knowledge pertaining to the assessment of an important workplace construct.

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ENDNOTES

[1] A full copy of the test described herein is available upon request (for research purposes only) from the first author.

[2] We thank an anonymous reviewer for suggesting this wording as a succinct characterization of our perspective.

[3] There were five SMEs that participated in the first round of review. Four of the SMEs were PhD students with a degree focus in industrial-organizational (I-O) psychology, two of which had already earned a master's degree in this area. The fifth SME had a master's degree in I-O. Collectively, these SMEs reported an average of 5.60 years of experience in their area of specialization (including academic training, internships, and professional experience). There were 11 SMEs in the second round of review. Six of the SMEs had PhDs with a degree focus in I-O, two of which were academic faculty members, while the remaining four worked in industry or consulting. The remaining SMEs had all earned master's degrees in I-O with the exception of one who was in the process of earning a joint I-O master's and law degree. Collectively, these SMEs reported an average of 5.77 years of experience in their area of specialization (including academic training, internships, and professional experience).

[4] Several steps were taken to ensure analyses were conducted on valid data. For all three samples, cases were removed if any of the following conditions were met: (a) the data were from pilot testing; (b) minimum study qualifications of age or employment status were not met; (c) less than 75% of the survey was completed; (d) multiple responses were from the same IP address; or (e) the survey was completed at a pace faster than two seconds per item. In addition, for samples 1 and 2, various attention check items were embedded in the survey (e.g., Please select the response option for 'Very Accurate') and any respondents answering incorrectly were removed. Lastly, the inclusion of multiple personality scales in sample 1 allowed for the calculation of an individual reliability score, where respondents with values <0.30 were removed (DeSimone, Harms, & DeSimone, 2015).

[5] One item was removed from this scale in sample 1 to improve internal consistency reliability.

[6] In support of this approach, prior work has examined the factorial structure of CWBs (Marcus et al., 2016). These authors found evidence for a complex structure, including an overall higher-order factor at the most general level, as well as additional lower-order factors at more specific levels. Such findings are concordant with Sackett and DeVore's (2001) suggestion that one can focus on different levels of abstraction for different purposes, including the prediction of on overall CWB outcome, or alternatively, the prediction of more specific categories of behavior.

[7] The pattern matrix, based on oblimin rotation, is included as supplemental online material.

[8] A problem occurred in a prior model, where the latent variable covariance matrix was not positive definite. This was the result of a slightly negative residual variance value for the latent variable corresponding to MD for misuse of time and resources. To correct this issue, the residual variance for this latent variable was set to zero for the model shown in Figure 2. The choice to focus on averaged scenario scores (as shown in Figure 2), as opposed to item-level data, was based on a consideration of the number of items in the MD-SJT (i.e., 76) and the size of sample 2 ($n = 339$). Nonetheless, for the sake of completeness, additional confirmatory factor analyses were run with all items as observed indicators. First, the model shown in Figure 2 was directly replicated with items, instead of averaged scenarios scores, as observed indicators ($\chi^2[2766] = 8{,}096.24$, $p < .01$; CFI = 0.75, TLI = 0.74; SRMR = 0.07). Model fit improved when grouping items within the 19 respective scenarios, as opposed to broader CWB categories, where the scenarios then served as latent indicators of a second-order general MD factor ($\chi^2[2755] = 4{,}591.39$, $p < .01$; CFI = 0.91, TLI = 0.91; SRMR = 0.05).

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information may be found online in the Supporting Information section.

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APPENDIX A

TABLE A1 Expanded correlation table for SJT and CWB Sub-Scales (Samples 1 and 2)

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
1. SJT theft or related behavior	—	0.784**	0.794**	0.794**	0.749**	0.817**	0.818**	0.764**	0.580**	0.569**	0.587**	0.476**	0.518**	0.521**	0.541**	0.495**
2. SJT destruction of property	0.636**	—	0.802**	0.755**	0.774**	0.819**	0.740**	0.780**	0.493**	0.478**	0.496**	0.420**	0.467**	0.452**	0.464**	0.432**
3. SJT misuse of information	0.437**	0.405**	—	0.790**	0.814**	0.816**	0.806**	0.737**	0.540**	0.547**	0.539**	0.413**	0.494**	0.460**	0.517**	0.442**
4. SJT misuse of time/resources	0.647**	0.591**	0.469**	—	0.787**	0.809**	0.804**	0.781**	0.562**	0.559**	0.560**	0.450**	0.531**	0.480**	0.544**	0.485**
5. SJT interpersonal misconduct	0.417**	0.358**	0.598**	0.460**	—	0.781**	0.839**	0.695**	0.540**	0.532**	0.534**	0.389**	0.521**	0.442**	0.525**	0.447**
6. SJT poor quality work	0.640**	0.708**	0.534**	0.603**	0.473**	—	0.792**	0.801**	0.525**	0.517**	0.529**	0.422**	0.465**	0.476**	0.495**	0.453**
7 .SJT unsafe behavior	0.515**	0.437**	0.597**	0.533**	0.645**	0.488**	—	0.668**	0.597**	0.610**	0.594**	0.401**	0.552**	0.488**	0.587**	0.468**
8. SJT poor attendance	0.646**	0.683**	0.440**	0.625**	0.354**	0.707**	0.406**	—	0.467**	0.446**	0.482**	0.470**	0.461**	0.471**	0.459**	0.466**
9. CWB theft or related behavior	0.395**	0.285**	0.311**	0.343**	0.275**	0.313**	0.396**	0.282**	—	0.942**	0.943**	0.782**	0.894**	0.830**	0.918**	0.838**
10. CWB destruction of property	0.314**	0.157**	0.290**	0.258**	0.267**	0.184**	0.394**	0.136*	0.781**	—	0.934**	0.733**	0.891**	0.798**	0.914**	0.805**
11. CWB misuse of information	0.367**	0.252**	0.329**	0.345**	0.242**	0.270**	0.319**	0.286**	0.748**	0.694**	—	0.793**	0.898**	0.839**	0.914**	0.842**
12. CWB misuse time/resources	0.355**	0.324**	0.257**	0.324**	0.147*	0.316**	0.133*	0.426**	0.449**	0.234**	0.542**	—	0.822**	0.886**	0.768**	0.869**
13. CWB interpersonal misconduct	0.289**	0.242**	0.367**	0.222**	0.347**	0.265**	0.353**	0.240**	0.657**	0.580**	0.628**	0.454**	—	0.858**	0.898**	0.836**
14. CWB poor quality work	0.397**	0.303**	0.325**	0.340**	0.222**	0.351**	0.270**	0.331**	0.561**	0.426**	0.663**	0.708**	0.538**	—	0.809**	0.847**
15. CWB unsafe behavior	0.232**	0.269**	0.324**	0.184**	0.223**	0.217**	0.249**	0.200**	0.505**	0.417**	0.560**	0.331**	0.535**	0.382**	—	0.820**
16. CWB poor attendance	0.321**	0.215**	0.206**	0.294**	0.166**	0.236**	0.240**	0.304**	0.477**	0.374**	0.491**	0.565**	0.444**	0.510**	0.293**	—

Note.: Correlations for sample 1 are below the diagonal and correlations for sample 2 are above the diagonal. For sample 1, $n = 294$. For sample 2, due to listwise deletion of cases with missing data, n ranges from 328–339. Descriptive statistics and reliability values for samples 1 and 2 can be found in Tables 7 and 8, respectively. SJT = Situational judgment test. CWB = Counterproductive work behaviors.

*$p < .05$.

**$p < .01$.